reporting done by the NDTV channels (yours truly included) during the Gujarat riots and its aftermath. In fact, during a Network 18 event in 2013, Modi made a snide remark that NDTV's 'Save the Tiger' effort got sponsorship because 'the tiger was secular and maybe the lion was seen as communal'. The BJP members in the audience laughed; I thought the remark was in rather poor taste.

Indeed, some things did not change even as Modi tried to appear more conciliatory towards the media. Whenever an interviewer asked a tough question (but very few did), you sensed a certain frostiness return to Modi's eyes. It happened when he was asked a question about his wife Jasodhaben and when an interviewer tried to push him once again on the riots. He chose to describe any criticism as being the handiwork of 'news traders', a rather unfortunate and ominous term that sadly no interviewer dared challenge. It was as if Modi had mentally divided journalists into camps and was urging his supporters to see any criticism of him as 'paid media', another regrettable term designed to put even professional journalists on the defensive.

The truth is, Modi was in full control. He was setting the terms of engagement with the news media and relishing the challenge. Most journalists were just grateful for the limited access and happy to be co-opted. A charismatic speaker, Modi knows what will 'sell' with the viewers and what won't. His ear for a good slogan or a line rarely fails him. While a Rahul Gandhi dithered after his initial faux pas, Modi was on a roll. Body language is also a potent communicator. A burly swagger compared with cutesy hand-waving became the default TV split screen for the Modi–Rahul personality clash. Modi on stage is a domineering figure with not a trace of tentativeness; Rahul, by contrast, looks like a shy schoolboy pushed into a dramatics class.

As one political observer put it, 'A doctorate in communication was being pitted against someone still in kindergarten!' It was a no contest. The prime-time battle had been settled.

~